

**INCLUSIVE MOBILE LEARNING APP FOR VISUALLY,
HEARING, PHYSICALLY AND COGNITIVELY
IMPAIRED STUDENTS (GRADE 3-5)**

25-26J-207

Individual Final Report

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Technology

Department of Information Technology
Sri Lanka Institute of Information Technology
Sri Lanka

April 2026

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(Final documentation in partial fulfilment of the requirement for the Degree of Bachelor
of Science Special (honors) In Information Technology Specializing in Information
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DECLARATION

I declare that this is my own work and this dissertation does not incorporate without acknowledgement any material previously submitted for a Degree or Diploma in any other University or institute of higher learning, and to the best of my knowledge and belief, it does not contain any material previously published or written by another person except where the acknowledgement is made in the text.

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ABSTRACT

Students in Sri Lanka with cognitive disabilities, including kids with cognitive and learning difficulties, face significant barriers in traditional classrooms due to standardized teaching methods, language barriers, and a lack of inclusive digital resources. While adaptive learning platforms and gamified systems exist internationally, they are rarely localized to the Sri Lankan context or tailored to different curriculum levels. This proposal introduces a Cognitive & Adaptive Mobile Learning Platform, designed using Flutter, Firebase, and TensorFlow Lite, that delivers personalized, gamified, and multi-sensory learning activities in Sinhala. The system adapts content difficulty to the learner's curriculum levels (below average, average, above average), while providing emotional guidance to maintain motivation and engagement.

The methodology employs a modular, iterative design that incorporates artificial intelligence, gamified micro-activities, and culturally relevant content. Real-world pilot testing will be conducted with students, supported by caregivers and educators, to evaluate effectiveness, usability, and engagement. The platform emphasizes accessibility through universal design principles, offline support, and progress-tracking dashboards for educators. With strong commercialization potential, the solution addresses a critical gap in inclusive education, offering a scalable pathway to enhance academic outcomes and social inclusion for students with cognitive disabilities in Sri Lanka.

Keywords: Cognitive & Adaptive Mobile Learning Platform, Cognitive disabilities, Personalised learning, Gamification

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

Several individuals and institutions contributed significantly to the successful completion of this research on cognitive and learning difficulties support. First, I would like to express my sincere gratitude to my supervisor, Prof. Nuwan Kodhagoda, and my co-supervisor, Ms. Jenny Krishara, for their continuous guidance, valuable insights, and encouragement throughout this study. Their support played a vital role in shaping the direction and quality of this research.

I would also like to thank the Sri Lanka Institute of Information Technology for providing the necessary academic environment and resources to carry out this work. My appreciation extends to the academic staff for their constructive feedback and support, which motivated me to further improve this research.

In addition, I am grateful to the National Institute of Education, the Zonal Education Office – Hatton, and Kalugala Maha Vidyalaya for their valuable guidance in understanding educational requirements and ensuring that the system aligns with real classroom learning needs.

Finally, I would like to express my heartfelt thanks to my family members and peers for their constant encouragement and support throughout this journey, which helped me complete this research.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

- AI: Artificial Intelligence
- API: Application Programming Interface
- ADHD: Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder
- CL: Curriculum Level
- HTTP: Hyper Text Transfer Protocol
- IQ: Intelligence Quotient
- SDK: Software Development Kit
- TLS: Transport Layer Security
- UDL: Universal Design for Learning
- WCAG: Web Content Accessibility Guidelines

LIST OF APPENDICES

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1. Background

Cognitive disabilities affect children's ability to learn, remember, and apply knowledge in classroom environments. In Sri Lanka, many primary school students with cognitive and learning difficulties experience challenges such as slower processing, weak memory retention, short attention spans, and difficulty with abstract reasoning [1], [6]. Traditional teaching practices, which rely heavily on uniform pacing and abstract explanations, often fail to meet these diverse needs, resulting in disengagement, low performance, and reduced inclusion.

Globally, about 2–3% of school-aged children in developing countries live with cognitive disabilities [2]. Within Sri Lanka, the standardized education system offers limited flexibility, which restricts opportunities for individualized learning and contributes to low self-esteem among these learners. Although specialized interventions exist, fewer than 5% of children who require support are able to access them, leaving a significant portion of students underserved.

Research has demonstrated that adaptive learning, gamified lessons, and visual aids can enhance learning outcomes for students with cognitive disabilities [3]. Personalized pacing, interactive activities, and real-time progress tracking help address diverse learning needs while maintaining motivation. However, most of these tools are designed for English-speaking contexts and are rarely tailored for Sinhala-speaking students.

Mobile learning applications supported by artificial intelligence (AI) and algorithms provide an opportunity to deliver personalized instruction, portability, and multimodal support [4]. These systems can adjust lesson difficulty in real time, match learning to individual cognitive profiles, and provide both academic and emotional support. For example, AI-powered adaptive frameworks have been proposed to align instructional complexity with learners' CLs, ensuring that lessons are neither overwhelming nor under stimulating [5].

Despite these advances, students in Sri Lanka continue to face barriers due to the lack of localized, inclusive, and curriculum-aligned platforms. Cognitive disabilities remain a critical challenge to equitable education, underscoring the need for an adaptive and culturally relevant mobile learning solution.

1.2. Literature Review

Adaptive learning systems for intellectual disabilities in developing countries [1]

This study examined adaptive learning systems for children with intellectual disabilities in developing countries. The authors showed that adaptive content sequencing and personalized feedback significantly improved academic engagement and retention compared to traditional classroom methods. The work demonstrates that low-cost adaptive solutions can address systemic limitations in resource-constrained contexts, which parallels the situation in Sri Lanka. This project, it provides evidence that adaptive technologies can deliver measurable gains even when teaching resources are scarce, supporting the need for a mobile, locally adapted platform.

Prevalence and classroom challenges of cognitive disabilities in Sri Lanka [2]

Focusing on Sri Lankan classrooms, this study mapped the prevalence of cognitive disabilities and documented common barriers such as memory retention difficulties, low attention, and poor comprehension under rigid teaching practices. The findings confirm that less than 5% of affected students receive targeted interventions. This local perspective strongly justifies your proposal, as it highlights the gap between student needs and the limited inclusive infrastructure available in schools, underscoring the urgency of a Sinhala-first adaptive learning platform.

Adaptive learning technologies: Systematic review and meta-analysis [3]

Through a systematic review and meta-analysis, the authors investigated adaptive technologies for learners with cognitive impairments. They found that tailored pacing, multimodal learning, and responsive feedback systems improved learning outcomes across different age groups. Importantly, the analysis highlighted the benefits of combining gamification with adaptation, making lessons shorter and more engaging.

Technology-enhanced learning environments [4]

This paper presented results from randomized controlled trials on technology-enhanced learning environments for students with cognitive disabilities. Evidence showed that structured digital interventions improved memory, processing speed, and classroom participation. The use of rigorous RCTs strengthens the credibility of digital solutions in education. For this project it emphasizes the importance of testing effectiveness through pilot studies with clear outcome metrics such as accuracy, engagement, and retention.

AI-driven personalized learning pathways for students with disabilities [5]

The authors explored AI-driven personalized learning pathways for children with learning disabilities. Their framework automatically adjusted lesson difficulty and content order based on learner profiles and real-time responses. This approach significantly improved motivation and reduced frustration. The relevance to this study is direct, as this proposed project aims to use CLs adaptation and dynamic difficulty scaling, ensuring that lessons are neither too easy nor overwhelming.

Cognitive processing challenges in Sri Lankan primary education [6]

This research focused on cognitive processing challenges in Sri Lankan classrooms, including difficulties in abstract reasoning, slow recall, and reduced attention. Teachers reported struggling to adapt lessons to diverse learner needs due to lack of training and tools. These findings explain why conventional instruction fails many students locally.

They provide critical justification for this proposed project emphasis on concrete examples, short tasks, and simplified digital interfaces in the proposed mobile app.

Inclusive Pedagogy framework for educational technology design [7]

This work introduced an inclusive pedagogy framework for designing educational technology. It emphasized providing multiple means of representation, engagement, and expression so that students with disabilities are not excluded. The framework is highly relevant to this system, guiding the integration of audio, visuals, animations, and text in Sinhala. It ensures the mobile app follows universal design principles that enable all learners to participate meaningfully.

Machine learning approaches for cognitive load optimization [8]

This survey reviewed machine learning approaches for adaptive educational systems, with a focus on optimizing cognitive load. The study stressed that balancing task difficulty and learner capacity prevents overload and increases retention. It provides theoretical support for using adaptive algorithms to modulate pacing and complexity. This project builds on this by tailoring lesson difficulty to children's CLs and performance in real time, thus controlling cognitive load.

Game-based micro-learning for students with attention difficulties [9]

The authors designed and validated game-based micro-learning activities for students with attention difficulties. Findings showed that short, game-like lessons increased focus and reduced dropouts. The principle of breaking content into smaller units directly supports the proposed project's micro-activity design. It confirms that gamification is not just motivating but also effective in sustaining learning for children with limited attention spans.

Gamification in special education: evidence-based approaches [10]

This research reviewed gamification practices in special education, highlighting how points, badges, and leaderboards can boost motivation and reinforce learning in students with cognitive disabilities. The study noted that gamification is most effective when linked to meaningful progress and feedback rather than just entertainment. This aligns with our proposed system's use of rewards, badges, and progress tracking to maintain engagement while reinforcing curriculum content.

Animated pedagogical agents in adaptive learning systems [11]

Baylor and Kim investigated the use of animated pedagogical agents in adaptive learning systems and reported improvements in motivation, emotional regulation, and learning outcomes among students with cognitive challenges. Their findings suggest that animated feedback can reduce frustration and encourage persistence. This evidence supports the integration of animated emotional guidance in the proposed Sinhala-based system, providing both academic and emotional benefits for learners.

Cultural localization in South Asian educational technology [12]

This research examined cultural localization in South Asian ed-tech platforms. It concluded that culturally relevant content and local language support significantly increase acceptance and effectiveness. Generic, Western-oriented tools often fail in rural Asian settings. This is highly relevant to our project, as we are prioritizing Sinhala-first design and curriculum alignment, ensuring the app resonates with local learners and teachers.

Universal design for learning with mobile classroom technology [13]

The authors applied Universal Design for Learning (UDL) to mobile classroom technology. Their framework included flexible learning pathways, accessible assessments, and multi-modal supports. Results showed that UDL increases participation of students with disabilities in mainstream classrooms. This directly informs the proposed system's flexible activity design, child-friendly interfaces, and multiple modes of learning support (text, voice, visuals).

AI-driven experiments in adaptive learning for special education [14]

This paper presented AI-driven adaptive learning systems applied to special education. It emphasized iterative experimentation and data analytics to refine interventions. The study suggests that constant monitoring and adjustment improve effectiveness. For the proposed project, this supports including progress dashboards and analytics for teachers, allowing iterative refinement of learning activities.

Digital divide adoption in Sri Lankan special education [15]

The authors discussed the digital divide in Sri Lankan special education, noting barriers such as poor infrastructure, limited training, and affordability issues. They recommended low-cost, offline-enabled solutions. This is directly relevant to the proposed platform, which supports offline mode, low-spec devices, and simple onboarding. It ensures accessibility even in rural schools where connectivity is limited.

Flexible collaborative scripts in multicultural learning contexts [16]

This study analyzed flexible collaborative scripts in multicultural educational contexts. It highlighted that rigid systems often fail in diverse environments and that adaptability to cultural and linguistic diversity is key. This proposed system reflects this principle by embedding Sinhala content, adapting tasks to CLs, and considering Sri Lankan pedagogy, making lessons contextually appropriate.

Accessibility design factors in blended learning environments [17]

The study reviewed design factors for accessibility in blended learning environments. It found that navigation clarity, consistent feedback, and simplified interaction design improved accessibility for learners with disabilities. These insights guide the newer proposed app's child-friendly interface, large buttons, simplified layouts, and clear interaction flows, ensuring usability for young learners with cognitive difficulties.

Inclusive education policies and implementation in South Asia [18]

This research analyzed inclusive education policy frameworks in South Asia, finding gaps between policy and classroom implementation. While policies promote inclusion, schools lack tools and training to operationalize them. This highlights the value of mobile platforms as a practical, scalable tool that can help implement inclusive policies at the ground level.

Layout and readability guidelines for Dyslexia and cognitive needs [19]

The authors proposed layout and readability guidelines to improve accessibility for students with dyslexia and cognitive impairments. Their web service demonstrated that font size, spacing, and color contrast directly affect comprehension. These findings influence the proposed design, where Sinhala typography, spacing, and child-friendly visuals must follow accessibility standards to reduce cognitive strain.

Cognitive telerehabilitation during COVID-19: A pilot study [20]

This pilot study explored cognitive telerehabilitation for adolescents with learning disabilities during COVID-19 lockdowns. The results showed that structured digital training maintained learning progress despite school closures. This confirms the feasibility of remote interventions and supports the proposed design of a mobile tool usable both in classrooms and at home with caregiver supervision.

Effects of cognitive training programs on school-age children [21]

Looney's research evaluated cognitive training programs for school-aged children and found improvements in working memory, attention, and processing speed. The results support the integration of targeted memory and attention-building exercises into digital platforms. The project builds on this by embedding such exercises within gamified micro-learning modules.

Scaffolding and inclusive co-Design for cognitive disabilities [22]

This work introduced scaffolding approaches for inclusive co-design with learners who have cognitive disabilities. It emphasized involving learners and caregivers in the design process and gradually reducing support as skills improve. The project can adopt this by embedding hints, guided steps, and teacher/caregiver collaboration, ensuring that learners are supported but also encouraged to become independent.

Assistive technologies for Dyslexia: multisensory review (2015–2023) [23]

Paudel reviewed assistive technologies for dyslexia, noting growth in multisensory tools (AR, VR, haptics). However, the review highlighted challenges of limited personalization, cost, and poor scalability in low-resource contexts. These findings align with the project's focus on lightweight, personalized, and locally sustainable solutions that avoid over-complexity while ensuring accessibility.

AI-based psychometric systems for adaptive tutoring [24]

Hu proposed an AI-based psychometric system for adaptive tutoring, linking cognitive assessments with personalized lesson delivery. The framework ensures that difficulty matches the learner's broader cognitive profile, not just past performance. The project takes inspiration from this approach by including CL-based assessments and adaptive adjustments, allowing activities to be matched to each child's cognitive level.

1.3. Research Gap

Global research has made strong progress in areas such as mobile learning, gamification, and adaptive education for students with cognitive disabilities. Even with these advances, there is still no solution that brings together CL-based adaptation, emotional guidance through animated characters, and Sinhala-language support for primary school students in Sri Lanka. Studies on assistive technologies for dyslexia show a growing use of multisensory tools like AR, VR, and haptic feedback. At the same time, these studies point out common issues such as weak personalization, short testing periods, and poor scalability in low-resource environments [22]. This shows a clear need for solutions that are culturally relevant, sustainable, and better tailored to individual learners in Sri Lanka.

A major challenge comes from the fact that many existing learning tools are designed mainly for English-speaking or Western users. Because of this, they often do not match the Sri Lankan curriculum or reflect the local cultural background. Instead of focusing on what students actually learn in schools, these platforms tend to offer general skill-based content. This makes it difficult to support learners at different ability levels, such as below average, average, and above average, since the content is not properly adapted to their needs [16].

There is also a limitation in how teaching methods are applied. Most systems focus on only one aspect, such as adjusting the learning pace or adding simple game elements. Very few platforms combine multiple methods in a balanced way. Features like real-time adaptation, animated guidance, and short interactive activities that use sound, visuals, and touch are rarely integrated together. These elements are especially important for children who have shorter attention spans and need continuous encouragement to stay engaged.

Accessibility and usability remain important concerns as well. Platforms like Google Classroom and Khan Academy provide a large amount of content, but they are not designed for children with cognitive difficulties to use on their own. Their interfaces can be complex, navigation is not always clear, and interactions may feel inconsistent. In addition, these systems often lack culturally familiar stories and examples, which makes it harder for students to relate to what they are learning [17].

Another clear gap is the lack of a complete, all-in-one solution. At present, no single platform offers adaptive learning activities based on CLs while also aligning with the Sri Lankan curriculum. Sinhala-language support through animated characters is limited, and gamified rewards are not always used effectively to motivate learners. The use of multisensory elements such as text, audio, images, and animations is also not well combined. Child-friendly accessibility features designed specifically for cognitive learners are still missing.

In addition, many of these applications are not supported by strong evaluation. Without proper testing through structured studies, it is difficult to confirm how effective these tools really are for the target users. Work in Instructional Design shows that careful design and validation are necessary to ensure learning systems truly support students.

Finally, long-term use and scalability are often not considered. Many research solutions do not take into account real-world constraints such as limited devices, internet access, and cost. These factors are especially important in countries like Sri Lanka. Because of this, even well-designed systems may not be widely used or maintained over time.

Feature Research	Sinhala Language	Performance- based adaptation	Gemification/ micro learning	Progress tracking and reporting
Proposed System	✓	✓	✓	✓
Anderson et al [4]	✗	PARTIALLY	✗	✓
Kiili & Kiili [9]	✗	✗	✗	PARTIALLY
Prenskey & Digital [10]	✗	✗	✗	PARTIALLY
Baylor & Kim [11]	✗	✗	✓	PARTIALLY
Hall, Meyer & Rose [13]	✗	✗	✗	✓
Maggio et al [20]	✗	✗	✗	✓
Looney [21]	✗	✗	✗	✓
Paudel [23]	✗	✗	✗	✗

Table 1.3.1: Comparison of Identified gaps with the existing system

1.4. Research Problem

In Sri Lanka, many primary school students with cognitive and learning difficulties with cognitive disabilities, including intellectual disabilities, ADHD, autism spectrum disorders, and specific learning difficulties, struggle to follow classroom lessons. Standardized teaching methods and fixed learning paces often overwhelm slower learners while failing to challenge others, leading to poor comprehension, slow progress, and disengagement.

- **Why is there a need to create a mobile learning app for students with cognitive and learning difficulties in Sri Lanka?**

Because many primary school students with intellectual disabilities, ADHD, autism, or specific learning difficulties struggle to keep up in traditional classrooms. Standard teaching methods move too fast for some and too slow for others, leading to poor comprehension, frustration, and disengagement.

- **What limitations exist in the current education system that make this app necessary?**

Sri Lankan classrooms mostly rely on chalk-and-talk teaching. Teachers often lack training in inclusive education, and fewer than 5% of students who need special support receive it. This creates a wide gap in equal learning opportunities.

- **Why are existing international tools not sufficient for these learners?**

Most global tools are designed for neurotypical students and focus mainly on visuals or adaptive testing. They do not combine emotional guidance, personalized pacing, and Sinhala-language support. As a result, they are not culturally relevant or usable for many Sri Lankan students.

- **Why is it important to introduce multi-modal and gamified learning?**

Children with cognitive difficulties learn better through multiple senses (hearing, seeing, touching, and interacting). Combining text, audio, images, animations, and games helps maintain attention, improve memory, and keep students motivated. Current tools rarely offer this in one platform.

- **What will happen if such an app is not developed?**

Without a localized, adaptive, and supportive tool, many Sri Lankan students with cognitive and learning difficulties will continue to fall behind academically. This not only reduces their personal educational outcomes but also limits national goals of inclusion and social development.

1.5. Research Objectives

1.5.1. Main Objective

The aim is to design, develop, and evaluate a mobile-based Cognitive & Adaptive Learning Platform using Flutter. The system will deliver personalized, engaging, and multi-sensory educational activities for Sri Lankan primary school students with cognitive and learning difficulties. Lessons will adapt to different CL (below average, average, above average) while providing emotional guidance and accessibility features to improve learning outcomes. Building on this, researchers have proposed AI-based psychometric tutoring frameworks that link cognitive assessments with adaptive content delivery [24]. Inspired by these ideas, this project will apply lightweight psychometric methods to ensure that content difficulty matches both learner performance and broader cognitive profiles.

1.5.2. Specific Objectives

- Conduct a multidisciplinary assessment of needs with teachers, psychologists, and caregivers to identify learning barriers and targeted support strategies that are required
- Develop an adaptive learning system using machine learning to adapt content, pace, and instruction based on a student's CL and existing performance
- Develop gamified micro-learning modules to sustain learner engagement and build cognitive skills through evidence-based pedagogy and game mechanics
- Embark on the deployment of animated emotional guidance agents to provide encouragement, corrective feedback, and supportive interventions at moments of frustration or disengagement
- Introduce multimodal accessibility features, such as Sinhala language support, voice guidance, and visual cues, aligned with global accessibility standards
- Implement an AI-based assessment module offering interactive quizzes with prompt feedback, tracking of progress, and rewards for achievement for formative and summative assessment

2. METHODOLOGY

The cognitive support module is designed as a closed-loop adaptive system that integrates game-based assessment, machine learning-based classification, and personalized activity delivery. The overall workflow consists of four main stages: data collection, feature engineering, model development, and adaptive personalization.

1. Data Collection through Game-Based Assessment

The process begins when a student logs into the system and accesses the CL assessment module. The assessment is conducted through three timed interactive games: shape matching, color matching, and bubble popping.

During gameplay, the system captures detailed interaction-based performance data, including:

- Total touches and valid taps
- Correct and incorrect responses
- Hint usage
- Response time
- Missed targets

These raw metrics reflect the student's attention, accuracy, and response behavior in a natural and engaging environment.

2. Feature Engineering

After completing the assessment, the collected raw data is processed to generate additional derived indicators such as:

- Accuracy
- Inefficiency
- Hint rate
- Miss rate

These derived metrics are combined with the raw inputs to construct a fixed 28-feature input vector. Maintaining a consistent feature order ensures reliability during both training and prediction phases.

3. Model Development and Training

A supervised learning approach is used to classify students into three cognitive performance levels: below average, average, and above average.

Data Preparation

The dataset, stored in CSV format, undergoes preprocessing steps including:

- Handling missing values
- Correcting label formats
- Ensuring feature consistency

The data is divided into:

- 90% labeled data for training and testing
- 10% unseen data for prediction

The labeled data is further split into training and testing subsets. Class labels are encoded into numerical values, and class weights are applied to address data imbalance.

Model Architecture

The classification model is implemented using TensorFlow and Keras as a sequential neural network consisting of:

- An input layer with normalization
- Two hidden Dense layers (128 units each)
- Batch normalization for stable training
- ReLU activation for non-linearity
- Dropout layers to reduce overfitting
- A final softmax output layer with three neurons (one per category)

Training Process

The model is trained using:

- Adam optimizer for efficient learning
- Sparse categorical cross-entropy as the loss function

Training is performed over multiple epochs with a defined batch size, while a validation split is used to monitor performance. Metrics such as accuracy and loss are recorded and visualized to evaluate learning progress.

4. Model Evaluation

The trained model is evaluated using:

- Accuracy scores
- Classification reports
- Confusion matrices

Additionally, the model is tested on a separate real-world dataset to assess practical performance. Visual analysis is used to better understand prediction behavior.

5. Deployment and On-Device Inference

After training, the model is converted into TensorFlow Lite (TFLite) format for efficient mobile deployment.

During runtime, the 28-feature vector generated from the assessment is passed to the on-device model, which outputs:

- Predicted cognitive category (below, average, above)
- Class probabilities
- Confidence score

6. Backend Integration and Data Storage

The complete result set—including student ID, raw metrics, derived features, prediction label, probabilities, and game scores—is transmitted to a backend API. The data is validated and stored in MongoDB to maintain historical records for each student.

7. Adaptive Personalization Mechanism

When the student accesses the cognitive dashboard, the latest prediction is retrieved and used to personalize learning activities:

- Below average → foundational activities
- Average → intermediate activities
- Above average → advanced activities

This creates a continuous adaptive cycle:

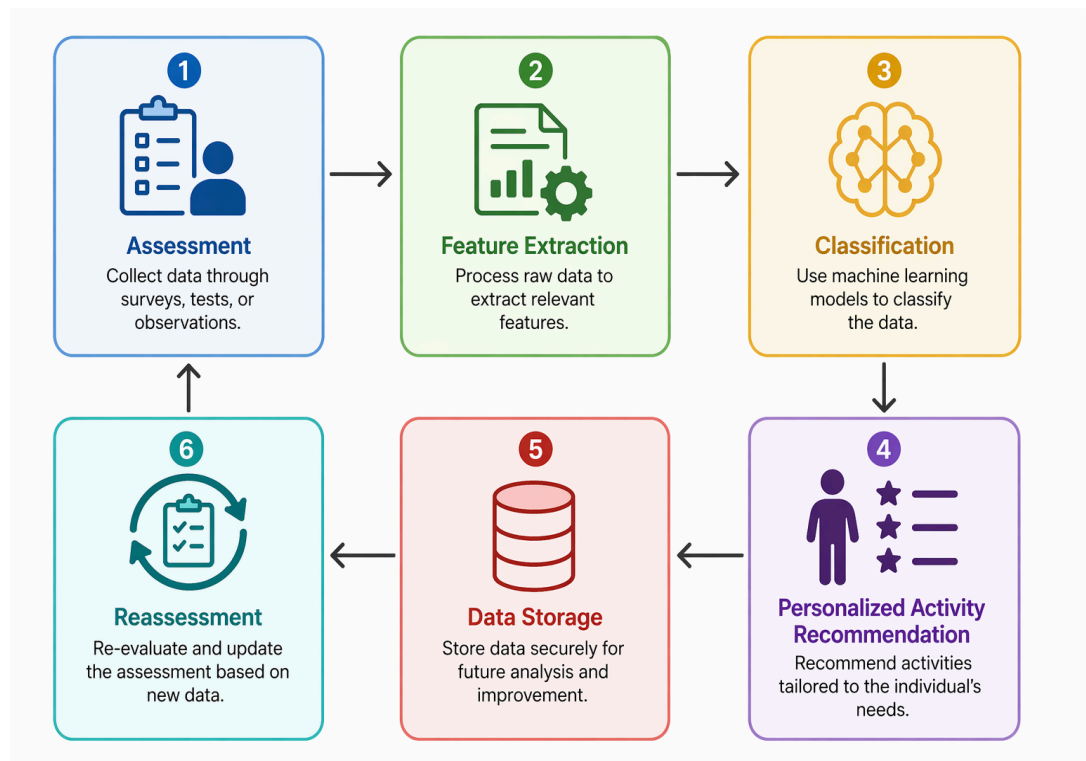


Fig. 2.1: Adaptive cycle for cognitive disability support

2.1. Summary of Methodology

This methodology combines interactive assessment, machine learning classification, and adaptive content delivery into a unified system. By continuously monitoring performance and updating predictions, the system ensures that learning experiences remain aligned with each student's cognitive ability, supporting effective and personalized learning outcomes.

2.2. System Architecture

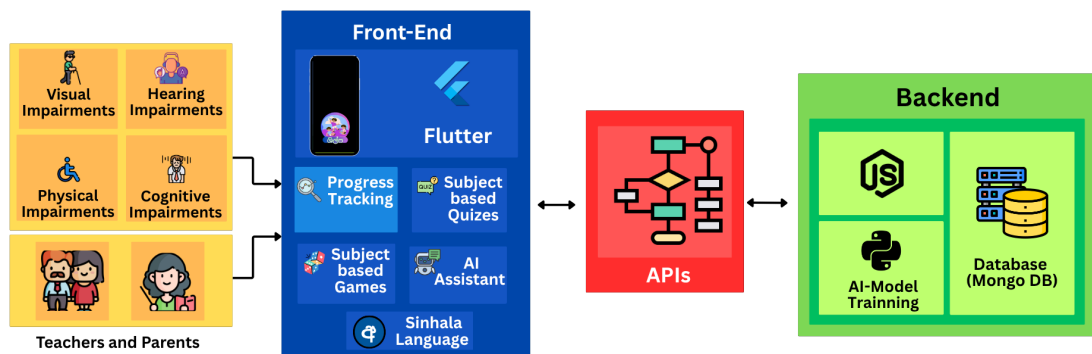


Fig.2.2.1: System overview diagram of the complete application

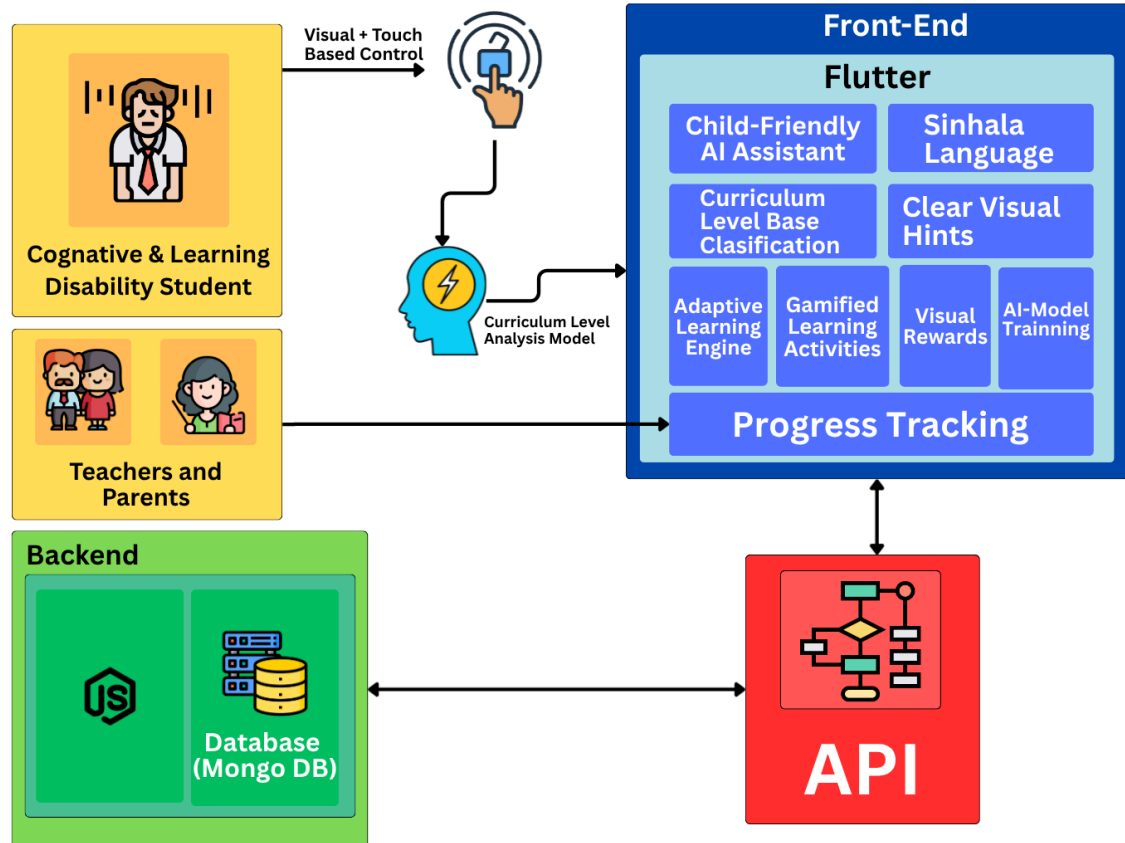


Fig. 2.2.2: System architecture overview for cognitive disability support

2.3. Project Requirements

2.3.1. Functional Requirements

The system must support data-driven evaluation and inclusive learning through the following functions:

- Monitor student behaviour and learning patterns during classroom use
- Collect structured feedback from teachers, parents, and psychologists
- Record performance metrics such as task completion, accuracy, engagement time, and progress
- Assess usability for students with cognitive disabilities
- Align lessons and activities with Sri Lankan curriculum standards
- Incorporate evidence from adaptive learning and assistive technology research
- Compare platform features with existing educational technologies
- Conduct pre-assessments to identify skills and preferences
- Deliver structured micro-activities during learning sessions
- Evaluate outcomes, motivation, and satisfaction after system use
- Track retention and engagement over time
- Apply statistical methods and algorithm testing to performance data
- Analyse feedback thematically and develop case studies to interpret behaviour patterns

2.3.2. Non-Functional Requirements

- Child-friendly with large buttons, clear visuals, and simple navigation
- Follows WCAG 2.1 AA, supports screen readers and voice control
- Interfaces customisable for different visual or motor needs
- Activities load within 2 seconds and run smoothly at 60fps
- Efficient memory use for low-spec devices and longer battery life

- Functions well under poor network conditions
- CDN for fast delivery and optimised education databases
- Data encrypted with HTTPS/TLS 1.3+
- Secure login with multi-factor authentication for admins
- Regular security audits and privacy compliance
- Modular design for easy updates and feature expansion
- Well-documented APIs for integration
- Automated tests covering 80%+ of core features, with version control and rollback
- Runs on Android (API 21+)
- Adapts to different screen sizes and device features
- Backwards compatible with older school devices in Sri Lanka

2.3.3. User Requirements

The system supports three main user groups. Students, Caregivers/Educators, and Administrators.

- Students (with Cognitive Disabilities)
 - Easy-to-use interface with simple navigation
 - Short activities (5–15 minutes) that match attention levels
 - Instant feedback with visuals and sounds for motivation
 - Multiple supports: Sinhala text-to-speech, animations, and interactive features
 - Difficulty levels that adapt to each student's ability and CL
 - Safe environment with age-appropriate content

- Caregivers and Educators
 - Tools to create/manage student profiles with CL and learning details
 - Real-time dashboards to track progress and outcomes
 - Options to set goals and customize learning paths
 - Detailed reports with Student current and past CL status
 - Alerts for performance changes or concerns
 - Training resources to use the platform effectively
 - Communication tools for collaboration with others

- System Administrators
 - Monitoring tools for system performance and usage.
 - Secure account and role management with permissions.
 - Content management for uploading and updating lessons.
 - Maintenance tools for updates, backups, and optimization.
 - Analytics dashboard showing overall usage and effectiveness.

2.4. Consideration of the Aspects of the System

2.4.1. Social Aspects

Standards:

During the development of the cognitive and learning support module, proper coding and design standards were followed to ensure consistency and quality. All components were implemented using object-oriented programming concepts, which helped maintain modularity and easy maintenance. Important sections of the code were clearly commented to improve readability and future updates. In addition, the documentation and report writing were prepared according to IEEE

formatting guidelines to ensure academic standardization. The design of the system also considers educational principles such as Cognitive Load Theory to structure content in a way that reduces unnecessary complexity and supports effective learning

2.4.2. Security Aspects

The cognitive and learning support feature of the Shilpa application is designed mainly for primary school children who face learning difficulties. It can also be useful for teachers, parents, and special education professionals who support these children in their learning process. The system provides a simple and engaging learning environment using games, visual elements, and adaptive activities, making it easier for children to understand lessons at their own pace.

This application does not require advanced technical knowledge. Basic familiarity with a smartphone is enough to use the system. The use of Sinhala language and simple instructions ensures that children in Sri Lanka can easily interact with the app without confusion. The platform encourages inclusive education by supporting children who struggle in traditional classroom environments.

By providing personalized learning experiences, the system helps reduce frustration and improves confidence among students. It also supports parents and teachers by giving insights into student performance. Overall, this module contributes positively to society by improving access to education for children with different learning abilities.

2.4.3. Ethical Aspects

This application is designed to support learning without causing any harm to users. It follows ethical guidelines by ensuring that the system does not mislead or negatively affect students. The platform does not replace teachers or professional educational support but acts as an additional tool to assist learning.

The system classifies students into different learning levels such as below average, average, and above average based on their performance. This classification is used only to provide suitable learning materials and should not be used to label or limit a student's abilities. Care is taken to ensure that the system encourages improvement rather than creating pressure.

All content is designed to be child-friendly, safe, and appropriate. The system respects user privacy and does not misuse any collected data. Overall, the application aims to provide a supportive and positive learning experience.

2.4.4. Limitations

- The system currently supports a limited dataset for training the learning model. More real-world data is needed to improve accuracy and reliability
- The classification model shows high accuracy in controlled environments, but performance may vary when applied to real users due to limited real data samples
- The application is mainly focused on Sinhala medium students, and support for other languages such as Tamil and English can be improved in the future
- The system is developed as a mobile application, so users without smartphones or stable internet access may face difficulties in using it
- The learning model provides suggestions based on performance, but it cannot fully understand emotional or psychological factors affecting a child's learning
- The system does not replace teachers or professional educational assessment; it only acts as a supportive learning tool
- Future improvements can include more advanced AI models, better personalization, and integration with teacher feedback systems

2.5. Commercialization aspects of the product

2.5.1. Target Audience

- Students in Grades 3–5, especially those with visual, hearing, physical, and cognitive learning difficulties
- Teachers involved in inclusive and special education
- Parents and guardians supporting children’s learning at home
- Schools, special education units, and educational institutions
- Government education bodies such as the National Institute of Education
- Researchers and developers in assistive technology and inclusive education

2.5.2. Market Space

- Designed for easy use with no requirement for advanced technical knowledge
- Suitable for Sinhala-medium users in Sri Lanka
- No prior experience with assistive technologies is required
- Can be used by both students and educators in inclusive learning environments
- Accessible to both urban and rural communities through mobile devices
- Potential to expand to other regions by adapting language and curriculum

2.5.3. Revenue Earning

- Subscription-based model for schools, institutions, and individual users
- Partnerships with educational institutions and government organizations
- Future collaborations with educational content providers

2.6. Testing and Implementation

2.6.1. Code Implementations for the research novelty

The cognitive learning module is a core component of the Shilpa mobile learning application, designed to support children with cognitive and learning difficulties through adaptive and personalized learning experiences. The system is implemented using a Flutter-based frontend, a Node.js/Express backend, and MongoDB for data storage. In addition, TensorFlow Lite is integrated to enable efficient on-device machine learning inference.

The architecture is designed to ensure smooth interaction between the user interface, data processing layer, and machine learning model. The mobile application handles user interaction and data collection, while the backend manages data storage and retrieval. The trained machine learning model is deployed in a lightweight format (TensorFlow Lite), allowing predictions to be performed directly on the mobile device.

The workflow begins when a student engages with interactive cognitive activities. These activities are carefully designed to align with primary-level learning objectives and include:

- Shape recognition tasks
- Color matching exercises
- Bubble interaction games

These activities are not only engaging but also structured to capture meaningful cognitive performance indicators during gameplay.

Cognitive Data Collection

During each activity session, the system continuously records student interactions and performance metrics. These include:

- Total taps and valid taps
- Number of correct and incorrect responses
- Reaction time for each action
- Number of hints used

These metrics provide a detailed representation of the student's cognitive behavior. For example, a higher number of correct responses indicates better understanding, while longer reaction times may suggest slower cognitive processing. Similarly, frequent hint usage may indicate the need for additional support.

```
mobile_app > lib > pages > games_cognitive > iq.dart > BaseTimedGameState > wrapWithTouchCounter
196 abstract class BaseTimedGameState<T extends StatefulWidget> extends State<T> {
295   Future<void> showEndDialogThenNext() async {
337     metrics.debugPrint(metrics.firstPlayKey, gameType);
338
339     if (!mounted) return;
340     onGameComplete(score);
341   }
342
343   Widget wrapWithTouchCounter({
344     required Gradient gradient,
345     required Widget child,
346   }) {
347     return Listener(
348       behavior: HitTestBeha Type: bool
349       onPointerDown: (_) { Declared in BaseTimedGameState in package:mobile_app/pages/games_cognitive/iq.dart.
350         if (gameActive && !isGameOver) {
351           metrics.totalTouches += 1;
352         }
353       },
354       child: Container(
355         decoration: BoxDecoration(gradient: gradient),
356         child: child,
357       ), // Container
358     ); // Listener
359   }
360
361   @override
362   void dispose() {
363     countdownTimer?.cancel();
364     disposeGameSpecific();
365     super.dispose();

```

Fig. 7.3.1.1: Code snippet for collecting cognitive assessment total touches

```
mobile_app > lib > pages > games_cognitive > iq.dart > _ShapeMatchGameState > checkMatch
1114 class _ShapeMatchGameState extends BaseTimedGameState<ShapeMatchGame> {
1289 void generateNewTarget({bool includeGameTitleAnnouncement = false}) {
1309   selectedShape = null;
1310   roundKey++;
1311   targetCardBg = pastelColors[roundKey % pastelColors.length];
1312 };
1313
1314   metrics.currentRoundStartedAt = DateTime.now();
1315   HapticFeedback.selectionClick();
1316   unawaited(
1317     _announceTarget(includeGameTitle: includeGameTitleAnnouncement),
1318   );
1319 }
1320
1321 Future<void> checkMatch(String shape) async {
1322   if (!gameActive || isGameOver) return;
1323
1324   metrics.validTaps += 1;
1325
1326   final now = DateTime.now();
1327   final rs = metrics.currentRoundStartedAt;
1328   if (rs != null) {
1329     metrics.reactionTimesSec.add(now.difference(rs).inMilliseconds / 1000.0);
1330   }
1331
1332   setState(() {
1333     selectedShape = shape;
1334     showHint = false;
1335     hintBlinkTimer?.cancel();
1336     hintBlinkOn = false;
1337   });
1338 }
```

Fig. 7.3.1.2: Code snippet for collecting cognitive assessment valid taps

Feature Preparation and Model Input

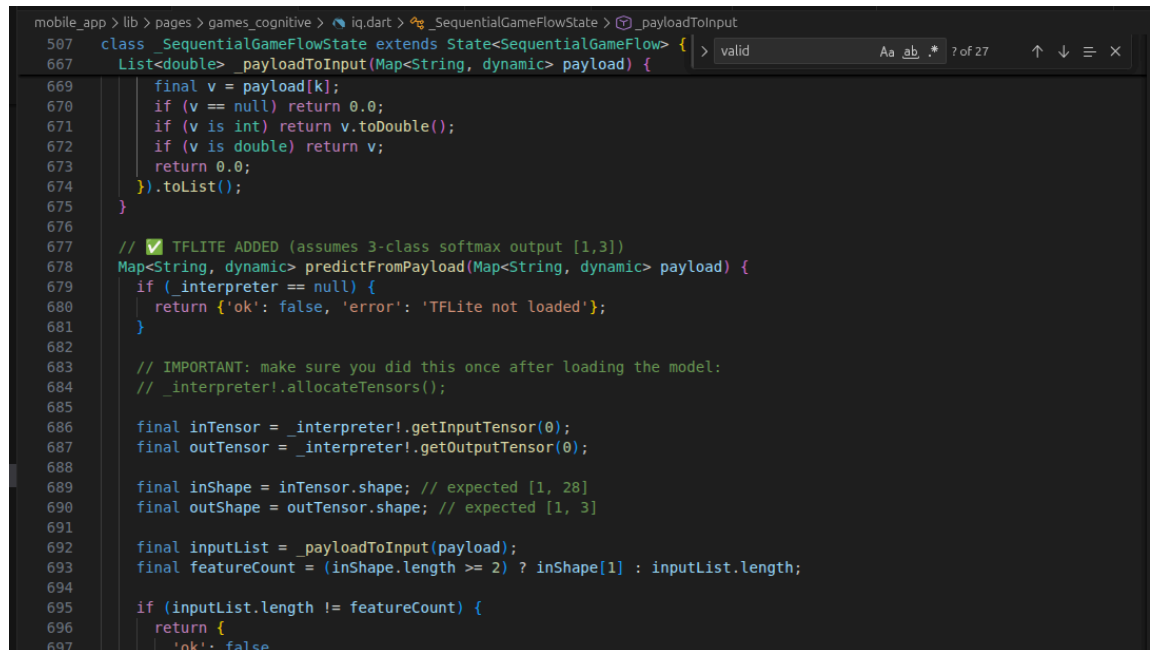
After collecting raw interaction data, the system processes these values into structured features. Derived features such as accuracy rates, inefficiency measures, and hint usage ratios are calculated. These processed features form the input vector for the machine learning model.

This step is important because raw interaction data alone is not sufficient for classification. Instead, meaningful patterns must be extracted to represent the student's learning behavior accurately.

On-Device Classification

The processed feature vector is passed to a TensorFlow Lite model embedded within the application. The model predicts the student's learning level into one of three categories:

- Below Average
- Average
- Above Average

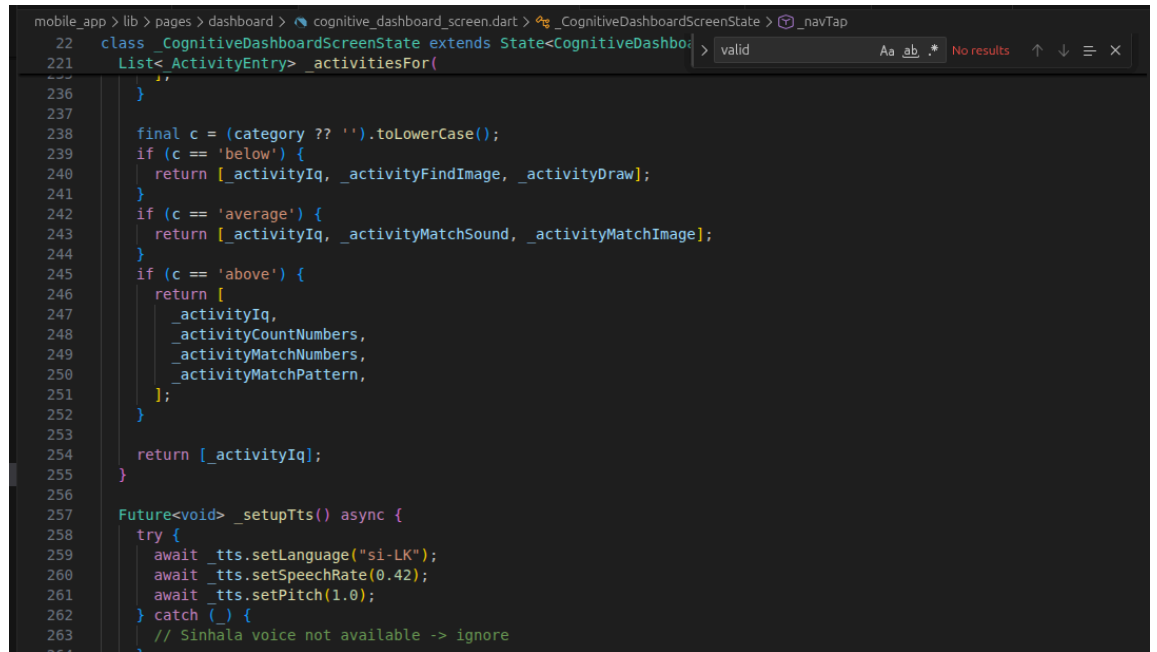


```
mobile_app > lib > pages > games_cognitive > iq.dart > _SequentialGameFlowState > _payloadToInput
507 class _SequentialGameFlowState extends State<SequentialGameFlow> {
667 List<double> _payloadToInput(Map<String, dynamic> payload) {
669     final v = payload[k];
670     if (v == null) return 0.0;
671     if (v is int) return v.toDouble();
672     if (v is double) return v;
673     return 0.0;
674   }).toList();
675 }
676
677 // TFLITE ADDED (assumes 3-class softmax output [1,3])
678 Map<String, dynamic> predictFromPayload(Map<String, dynamic> payload) {
679   if (_interpreter == null) {
680     return {'ok': false, 'error': 'TFLite not loaded'};
681   }
682
683   // IMPORTANT: make sure you did this once after loading the model:
684   // _interpreter!.allocateTensors();
685
686   final inTensor = _interpreter!.getInputTensor(0);
687   final outTensor = _interpreter!.getOutputTensor(0);
688
689   final inShape = inTensor.shape; // expected [1, 28]
690   final outShape = outTensor.shape; // expected [1, 3]
691
692   final inputList = _payloadToInput(payload);
693   final featureCount = (inShape.length >= 2) ? inShape[1] : inputList.length;
694
695   if (inputList.length != featureCount) {
696     return {
697       'ok': false,
```

Fig. 7.3.1.3: Code snippet for learning level classification

Personalized Activity Recommendation

Based on the predicted learning level, the system dynamically adjusts the learning content. Students who fall into the “below average” category receive simpler and more guided activities, while “above average” students are given more challenging tasks.



```

mobile_app > lib > pages > dashboard > cognitive_dashboard_screen.dart > _CognitiveDashboardScreenState > _navTap
22  class _CognitiveDashboardScreenState extends State<CognitiveDashboardScreen> {
221  List<ActivityEntry> _activitiesFor(
222    String category,
223  ) {
236  }
237
238  final c = (category ?? '').toLowerCase();
239  if (c == 'below') {
240    return [_activityIq, _activityFindImage, _activityDraw];
241  }
242  if (c == 'average') {
243    return [_activityIq, _activityMatchSound, _activityMatchImage];
244  }
245  if (c == 'above') {
246    return [
247      _activityIq,
248      _activityCountNumbers,
249      _activityMatchNumbers,
250      _activityMatchPattern,
251    ];
252  }
253
254  return [_activityIq];
255  }
256
257  Future<void> _setupTts() async {
258    try {
259      await _tts.setLanguage("si-LK");
260      await _tts.setSpeechRate(0.42);
261      await _tts.setPitch(1.0);
262    } catch (_) {
263      // Sinhala voice not available -> ignore
264    }
265  }

```

Fig. 7.3.1.4: Code snippet for activity recommendation

This adaptive mechanism ensures that each student receives content suitable to their ability level, which improves engagement and learning effectiveness.

2.6.2. Model Training Process

The classification model used in the cognitive module is developed using a supervised learning approach. The model is trained on a dataset consisting of cognitive performance features and corresponding learning level labels.

The dataset includes both synthetic data (generated based on predefined conditions) and a real dataset collected from user interactions. The synthetic dataset helps in initial model learning, while the real dataset is used for validation and performance assessment.

Training Configuration

The model is trained using standard machine learning practices, including:

- Multiple training epochs
- Mini-batch processing
- Validation split for monitoring performance
- Class weighting to handle imbalance
-

```
# =====  
# 7) Train  
# =====  
history = model.fit(  
    X_train, y_train,  
    epochs=EPOCHS,  
    batch_size=BATCH_SIZE,  
    validation_split=VALIDATION_SPLIT,  
    class_weight=class_weight_dict,  
    # callbacks=callbacks,  
    verbose=1  
)  
  
..
```

Fig. 7.3.2.1: Model training

During training, both loss and accuracy are monitored to ensure that the model is learning effectively without overfitting.

2.6.3. Model Evaluation

Evaluation on Synthetic Test Data

After training, the model is evaluated on a separate test dataset. This evaluation measures how well the model generalizes to unseen data.

```
loss, acc = model.evaluate(X_test, y_test, verbose=0)
print("\nTest loss:", loss)
print("Test accuracy:", acc)
```

Fig. 7.3.3.1: Model evaluation

Additional evaluation metrics such as precision, recall, and F1-score are calculated using a classification report. A confusion matrix is also generated to analyze prediction accuracy across different classes.

Custom Test Case Analysis

To further verify model behavior, specific test cases are introduced. These cases simulate different cognitive scenarios, including extreme conditions such as very low performance.

```
probs = model.predict(X_test, verbose=0)
pred = np.argmax(probs, axis=1)

# Print the predicted values for the first 10 samples
print("\nPredicted values for the first 10 samples:")
print(pred[:10])
```

Fig. 7.3.3.2: Test case analysis

This step helps confirm that the model produces logical and consistent predictions even under unusual conditions.

Evaluation on Real Dataset

To validate real-world applicability, the model is tested on a dataset collected from actual users.

```
# Extract features using same order
X_real = df_real[feature_cols].to_numpy(dtype=np.float32)

# Convert labels
y_real_str = df_real[LABEL_COL].values
y_real = np.array([label_to_idx[v] for v in y_real_str])

# Predict
real_probs = model.predict(X_real)
real_pred = np.argmax(real_probs, axis=1)

# Accuracy
real_accuracy = np.mean(real_pred == y_real)
```

Fig. 7.3.3.3: Evaluation on Real Dataset

The results indicate that the model performs reliably in real scenarios, although accuracy is slightly lower than in synthetic testing due to natural variations in human behavior.

2.6.4. System Testing

A comprehensive testing approach was followed to ensure system reliability and correctness.

Functional Testing

Functional testing verified that all features operate as expected. This includes:

- Correct calculation of metrics
- Proper handling of hints
- Smooth game completion flow

Integration Testing

Integration testing ensured seamless communication between system components, including:

- Data transfer from mobile app to backend
- API responses and data storage
- Retrieval of stored session data

Model Testing

Model testing focused on verifying that:

- Feature inputs are correctly processed
- Predictions match expected outcomes
- Output labels are accurate and meaningful

Testing Summary

Test ID	Test Scenario	Input	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status
T-01	Metric calculation	Game inputs	Correct metrics	Working	Pass
T-02	API submission	Session data	Stored in the database	Working	Pass
T-03	Classification	Feature vector	Correct level output	Working	Pass

Table 7.3.4.1: Testing summary

2.6.5. Pilot Survey Evaluation

A pilot study was conducted to evaluate the usability and effectiveness of the cognitive module. The study involved students, teachers, and parents.

Students interacted with the application while observers recorded their behavior, engagement, and ease of use. Feedback was collected through discussions and observations.

Findings

- Students found the application easy to understand
- Activities were engaging and enjoyable
- Personalized recommendations improved the learning experience

Limitations Identified

- Some instructions need to be clearer
- Feedback response time can be improved

2.6.6. Summary

The cognitive module demonstrates a complete adaptive learning workflow, combining:

- Real-time data collection
- Machine learning-based classification
- Personalized learning recommendations

The implementation confirms that the system works effectively as an intelligent learning support tool. Testing results show that the system is reliable, and the pilot evaluation indicates that it is suitable for real-world use in supporting children with cognitive and learning difficulties.

2.7. Tools & Technologies

- Flutter SDK
- Node.js
- Python
- Firebase
- Google Colab
- Keras
- TensorFlow Lite
- Gamification Techniques

- Figma
- Android Studio
- WCAG 2.1 & UDL Guidelines - used to ensure accessibility and inclusive design for learners with diverse needs

3. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

3.1. Results

The cognitive and learning difficulties support module was developed to identify student learning levels and provide personalized learning experiences. The system was evaluated using both a synthetic dataset and a limited real-world dataset collected from students.

The trained classification model categorized students into three levels:

- Below Average
- Average
- Above Average

During testing, the model showed very high accuracy when evaluated on the synthetic dataset, achieving close to perfect performance. This indicates that the model successfully learned the patterns present in the training data.

However, when tested with real student data, the performance dropped to approximately 82–83% accuracy. This difference highlights the gap between controlled training data and real-world conditions.

The system also recorded student interaction data such as:

- Response accuracy
- Time taken to answer
- Number of attempts
- Hint usage

These inputs were used to dynamically adjust the learning path. Students who struggled were given simpler tasks, while students who performed well received more challenging activities.

Overall, the results show that the system can:

- Identify learning levels with reasonable accuracy
- Adapt content based on student performance
- Support personalized learning in a practical environment

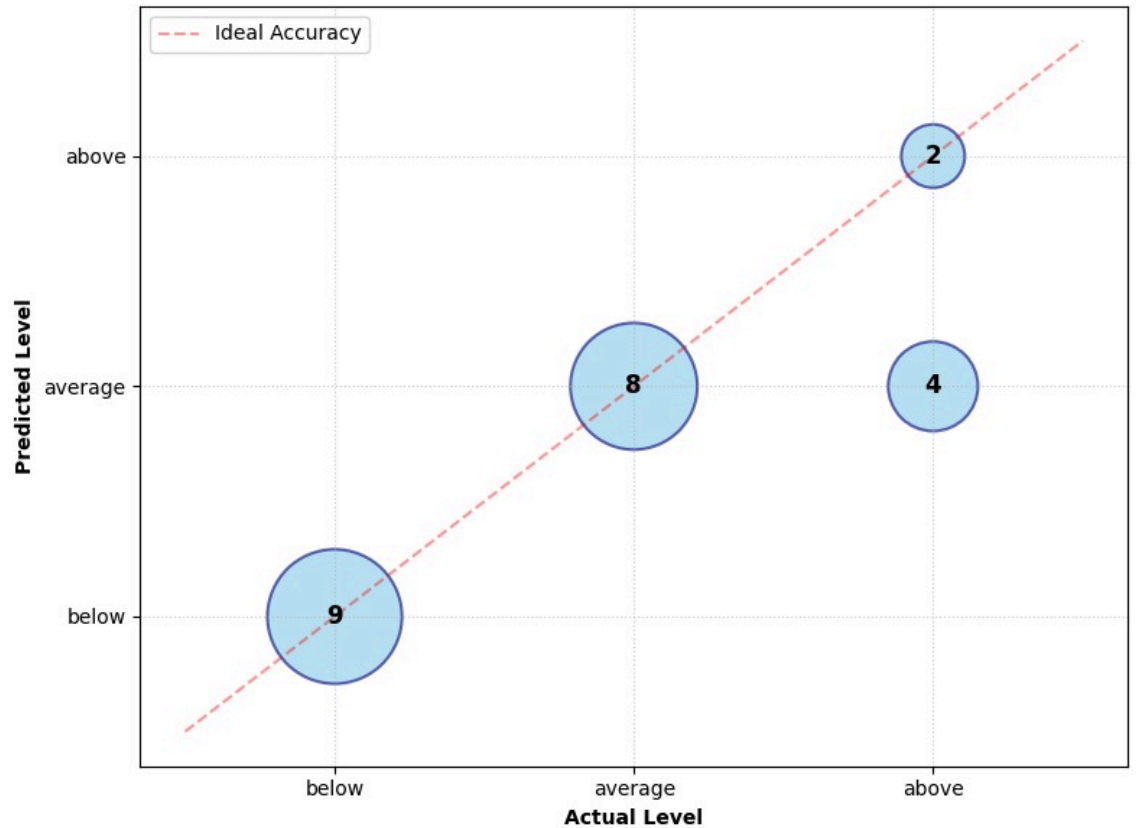


Fig. 8.1.1: Comparison between Actual level and Predicted level

3.2. Research Findings and Discussions

The findings of this study show that adaptive learning systems can effectively support children with cognitive and learning difficulties when designed carefully.

One key observation is the difference between synthetic and real-world performance. While the model achieved near-perfect accuracy in controlled conditions, real-world accuracy was lower. This suggests that:

- Real student behavior is more complex and less predictable
- The dataset used for training does not fully represent real learning scenarios
- More real data is needed to improve reliability

Another important finding is the value of game-based learning. Students showed better engagement when interacting with:

- Short activities
- Visual elements
- Immediate feedback

This supports existing research in Cognitive Load Theory, which explains that structured and simple content helps reduce mental overload and improves understanding.

The adaptive mechanism also proved to be useful. Instead of giving the same content to all students, the system:

- Adjusts difficulty based on performance
- Provides additional support when needed
- Encourages progress at an individual pace

This approach helps overcome a common problem in traditional classrooms, where all students are expected to learn at the same speed.

Despite these strengths, some limitations were identified:

- Small real-world dataset

- Limited testing duration
- Possible bias from synthetic data

Even with these limitations, the system demonstrates strong potential for real-world application, especially in inclusive education environments.

4. CONCLUSION

This research focused on developing a cognitive and learning support module as part of the Shilpa inclusive learning platform. The goal was to help children with learning difficulties by providing adaptive and personalized learning experiences.

The results show that the system can successfully classify students into different learning levels and adjust content accordingly. While the model performed extremely well during training, real-world testing showed moderate accuracy, indicating the need for further improvement using real student data.

The use of adaptive learning, simple activities, and interactive design helped improve student engagement and made the learning process more accessible. This is especially important for children who struggle in traditional classroom environments.

The system also demonstrates that combining machine learning with educational principles can create meaningful support tools for inclusive education.

In the future, the system can be improved by:

- Collecting more real-world data
- Expanding content based on the school curriculum

- Supporting multiple languages such as Sinhala and Tamil
- Enhancing model accuracy with continuous learning

In conclusion, this study confirms that adaptive mobile learning systems can play an important role in supporting students with cognitive and learning difficulties, making education more inclusive and effective.

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